Report on "Matrix Theory Reloaded: A BPS Road to Holography"

Blair, Lahnsteiner, Obers and Yan

Summary of the paper

The paper revisits the decoupling limits that define matrix theory. It treats them as *BPS* limits: the Dp-brane tension is tuned against its RR charge, and the limit is applied to the whole type II string theory, not just to the brane. The ten-dimensional target space then becomes non-Lorentzian. It carries a codimension-$(p+1)$ foliation and a p-brane Galilean boost symmetry, and the resulting corner is called matrix p-brane theory (MpT).

Three further results follow.

- Applied to a curved Dp-brane background, the same limit produces the near-horizon (AdS/CFT-type) geometry.
- Applying two such limits in succession gives new, non-Lorentzian holographic pairs. The authors organise these as a conjectured DLCQ^n/DLCQ^m correspondence with $m > n$.
- Undoing the limits is a p-brane generalisation of the $T\bar{T}$ deformation. This gives explicit flow equations for the Dirac–Nambu–Goto action for any p, and for the D1 and D2 DBI actions.

1 Principal achievement

The main achievement is a single geometric mechanism that links three areas usually treated separately: matrix theory, AdS/CFT, and $T\bar{T}$-type deformations.

The paper shows that the near-horizon limit of a Dp-brane geometry is the same BPS decoupling limit that gives matrix theory at asymptotic infinity. For example, the $\mathrm{AdS}_5 \times S^5$ metric has the form of the MpT limit, with $(r/\ell)^2$ playing the role of the limit parameter ω. This answers the long-standing question of how the Lorentzian bulk relates to the non-Lorentzian geometry that the matrix theory sees. Reading the limit backwards also gives the bulk as a deformation of the asymptotic geometry. That reading yields new, explicit p-brane $T\bar{T}$ flow equations, for example

$$\partial_\lambda \mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{4}\big[\operatorname{tr}\mathcal{T}^2 - (\operatorname{tr}\mathcal{T})^2 + 2\lambda \det \mathcal{T}\big] \quad (p=2).$$

The flow equations are a concrete, checkable output of the framework that stands on its own as field theory. The DLCQ classification gives a systematic way to generate candidate holographic duals, instead of constructing each one by hand. It also explains why existing non-Lorentzian examples (the recent Lambert et al. proposals) belong together.

2 Principal drawback

The most important drawback is that the new, non-Lorentzian holographic claims remain conjectural and largely unverified, and the paper says so in its Outlook. Several points stand out.

- The non-Lorentzian bulk geometries rely on an extra rescaling of the harmonic-function scale ℓ with ω, inserted by hand. The authors state that the physical interpretation of this rescaling (effectively a rescaling of N) is unclear.
- They also state that they did not check that these geometries solve the equations of motion and torsional constraints of MpT supergravity. That supergravity has not been formulated explicitly. Their supersymmetries, charges and isometry groups have not been computed.
- The DLCQ^n/DLCQ^m conjecture is supported by pattern-matching on examples (Dp, M2, M5, D1–D5), with no independent test or observable, such as a correlator or a thermodynamic quantity, compared across the two sides.
- The flow equations are classical, bosonic and abelian. The $p = 3$ case is known only to linear order in λ. The cases $p > 3$ need strong-coupling or dual descriptions. The non-abelian and supersymmetric versions that would connect to the actual matrix theories are not constructed.

The unifying framework is elegant, but the evidence that it produces consistent new dualities, rather than a classification of limits, is thin.

3 Most promising follow-up idea

Proposal: put the non-Lorentzian holographic duals on solid footing by constructing the bosonic MpT supergravity equations and testing the proposed near-horizon solutions against them, starting with the simplest cases.

This choice was made on feasibility and impact.

1. *Construction.* Obtain the MpT supergravity equations, for $p = 0$ and $p = 1$ first, as the limit of the type II equations. Alternatively, obtain them from beta functions of the non-relativistic string, which is known for $p = 1$. Use the non-Lorentzian vielbein (τ, E) formalism and the torsional constraints that the paper discusses. Targets for the first stage are the $p = 0$ and $p = 1$ equations, which have close precedents in the non-relativistic string and M2-brane literature.
2. *Test.* Substitute the double-limit Dq-brane geometries of the paper's holography sections (both the localised and the smeared versions). Fix the physical meaning of the ω-rescaling of N. Decide which solutions are acceptable and which are artefacts.
3. *Consequences.* For the surviving solutions, compute the isometry algebra, the preserved supersymmetry and the charges. Then compute one observable on both sides, for example the finite-temperature free energy or a Wilson-loop-type quantity. The non-relativistic limit of the dual field theory gives the comparison.

Why this one. It is the step on which the paper's boldest claims depend (non-Lorentzian holography and the DLCQ^n/DLCQ^m conjecture), so success or failure carries a large payoff. It is also well-defined and incremental: it uses limiting procedures that already exist, with the closest precedents being the M2-brane analyses cited in the paper, and the cases $p = 0, 1$ keep the algebra manageable. A negative outcome is informative as well, since it would show which parts of the classification survive.

Runner-up (lower risk, lower impact). Use the $p = 2$ flow equation, which coincides for the D2- and M2-brane, to attempt a non-abelian extension. The test would be whether it can be applied to BLG/ABJM and whether its endpoint is a non-abelian DBI-type action. This is a clean question but would mainly extend the field-theory side, while the holographic side is where the main uncertainty lies.